Robodebt and Helm Failure

Pre-analysis question register

Version: 1.0 — question register, not a completed statistical analysis plan.
Prepared: 13 November 2026.
Status: Proposed for investigator approval and independent timestamping before analysis.
Study materials: Existing, already-scored, blinded CAMS records described by the investigator as covering Australia, the Morrison government, Cabinet, the prime minister and CES/Centrelink. Actual dataset boundaries remain to be verified without inspecting analytical values.
Access statement: No CAMS files were supplied to, inspected or analysed by the assistant preparing this register. The investigator reports scoring is complete, the data are blinded and no analysis has begun. This statement does not independently certify those conditions.

Evidence and the prior

The Helm-failure hypothesis has substantial evidentiary support, but its stronger motivational claims require separate tests. The Royal Commission documented ministerial and administrative failures and the use of recipients' information to discourage criticism; Alan Tudge disputed the adverse finding about his media strategy. See the Royal Commission report, especially chapter 6, and the record of ministerial findings and responses. [cite:439][cite:466]

Those findings do not establish that Morrison personally designed the programme chiefly to demoralise political opponents, that recipients were selected by political allegiance, or that allies experienced pleasure at their suffering. Those are distinct claims, not implications of a CAMS score. The Royal Commission also identified anti-welfare rhetoric as longstanding and cross-party, so Australian historical uniqueness cannot be assumed. [cite:439]

The bureaucratic-misinformation alternative must receive a fair test. The NACC's Operation Myrtleford findings concerned specified conduct, found serious corrupt conduct by two officials and did not find corrupt conduct by the other four referred individuals; they did not re-examine the scheme as a whole. [cite:305]

Declared substantive prior: The investigator suspects that executive political incentives distorted lawful welfare administration, weakened correction and imposed avoidable demoralisation on recipients and critics. The stronger claims of personal hostile purpose, partisan targeting, pleasure in suffering and historical uniqueness are not assumed. Evidence against executive primacy will receive the same reporting prominence as evidence supporting it.

Central distinction: A Helm may be politically effective and internally coordinated while failing its lawful public mandate. Neither low coherence nor high coherence will count as evidence of failure without an independently specified mechanism and outcome.

Institutional boundaries

Morrison became prime minister on 24 August 2018, having previously served as social services minister and treasurer. Origins, continuation and termination must therefore be separated by office, authority and period; a PM-only record cannot establish responsibility for earlier origins. See the National Archives biography. [cite:463]

CES and Centrelink are not interchangeable institutional labels: official history distinguishes the Commonwealth Employment Service established in 1946 from Centrelink launched in 1997. A combined series needs an explicit lineage and comparability account. See Services Australia agency history. [cite:448]

Keep the PM/PM's office, Cabinet, portfolio ministers, senior administrators, frontline staff and recipients analytically distinct. Do not use a government-level score as a psychological measure of one person.

Primary question family

Q01–Q06 are the proposed primary family. Freeze one measurable signature, estimand, comparison, window and decision rule per question in an implementation addendum before score access. If the existing data and codebook cannot measure a proposed mechanism, classify it as not testable. Do not invent a new metric after reveal.

Q01 — Temporal precedence

Does an adverse executive change precede deterioration in Centrelink's recipient-facing functioning?

Prediction: a locked executive signature leads the agency signature at a lag the sampling interval can resolve. Weakening evidence: agency deterioration precedes executive change, the executive signal is absent, or chronology is reversed. Same-period observations leave direction unresolved.

Q02 — Effective execution, adverse service

Does executive policy-execution strength coexist with worsening recipient-facing functioning?

Prediction: maintained or increased executive coordination or execution capability accompanies independently defined deterioration in lawful service. Weakening evidence: general, parallel deterioration without the predicted asymmetry. High executive coherence alone is not corroboration.

Q03 — Corrective feedback

Does corrective information become less effectively connected to executive action?

Prediction: a locked Archive–Helm or oversight–executive mismatch increases alongside independently documented failure to revise policy after credible warnings. Weakening

evidence: information transmission and remedy remain effective, or the proposed mismatch is absent. Symmetric similarity cannot by itself demonstrate message suppression or direction.

Q04 — Persistence after warning

After independently dated warnings, does harmful policy persist without a proportionate corrective response?

Prediction: locked adverse service indicators persist beyond warning dates without substantive correction in the locked response window. Weakening evidence: prompt substantial correction or no observable persistence. Distinguish warning issuance from receipt by the responsible office.

Q05 — Institutional specificity

Is the proposed signature more concentrated in Robodebt-relevant institutions than in Australia generally?

Prediction: the executive–agency pattern exceeds the locked national or available comparison pattern after considering common trends. Weakening evidence: broad equivalent deterioration with no programme-specific concentration. An aggregate containing Centrelink is not an independent control.

Q06 — Reversal and repair

Does ending income-averaged debt raising precede improvement in the affected service functions?

Prediction: improvement appears in the locked subsequent window in functions expected to respond. Weakening evidence: improvement is absent, precedes termination, or also appears in unaffected functions. Inadequate follow-up and concurrent shocks may make this inconclusive.

No majority vote across these questions establishes intentional cruelty. Any joint rule requires separate advance specification.

Pathway questions

Secondary unless explicitly promoted before analytical access:

Q07 — Location. Where is the earliest resolvable departure: PM, Cabinet, portfolio ministers, senior administration, frontline operations or Australia generally? Can the data distinguish these levels?

Q08 — Vertical divergence. Do Cabinet and departmental leaders remain mutually aligned while diverging from staff and recipients, or does fragmentation originate inside the executive?

Q09 — Upward transmission. Can the evidence distinguish information not generated, not transmitted, distorted in transmission, and received but disregarded? Which mechanisms remain unidentified?

Q10 — Coordination versus correction. Does strong executive coherence support effective correction or policy persistence despite adverse evidence? What independent observation establishes that correction was warranted?

Q11 — Administrative abstraction. Does an existing abstraction measure identify proxy-driven administration that loses relevant individual information, while distinguishing abstraction that improves service?

Q12 — Burden displacement. Does maintained executive or administrative performance accompany rising staff or recipient stress? Are those populations actually measured rather than inferred from national Hands scores?

Q13 — Recognition versus remedy. How long passes between warning receipt, acknowledgement, investigation, suspension and substantive remedy? Are those stages separately defined?

Q14 — Persistence and repair. Following termination, do stress and impaired relationships persist during refunds, litigation and institutional repair? Does the frozen dataset cover that period?

Rival explanation questions

Q15 — Bureaucratic origin. Do administrative initiative or misinformation subsequently accepted by ministers explain the sequence better than executive-originating distortion? What would require withdrawal of executive primacy?

Q16 — Fiscal objective. Can savings and debt-recovery targets explain the pattern without partisan hostility? What observation genuinely discriminates these accounts?

Q17 — Technical failure. Can data, automation and delivery constraints explain initial failure, and can they also explain persistence after legal and human consequences became known?

Q18 — Distributed failure. Are failures sufficiently spread across ministers, departments, lawyers and oversight bodies to favour a multi-institutional account rather than a single-Helm explanation?

Q19 — Inherited conditions. Does deterioration precede the relevant ministerial appointment or government? Without a baseline, must the proposed executive-induced break remain unresolved?

Q20 — General pressure. Do staffing constraints, workload, wider welfare changes or common shocks explain the trajectory as well as, or better than, the preferred account?

Q21 — Role transition. Is there a resolvable change when Morrison becomes PM, or stronger continuity across his earlier offices and other prime ministers?

Q22 — Placebos and controls. Does the identical detection rule find similar apparent failures at independently selected non-event dates or in suitable comparison functions? Does its false-alarm rate undermine specificity?

Intent and political targeting

These questions require evidence beyond system state vectors. Without it, record not established, not an invented numerical proxy for intent.

Q23 — Harm intended or accepted. What distinguishes a purpose to demoralise from indifference, recklessness, tolerated collateral harm or mistaken legitimate enforcement? Are programme creation and later defence considered separately?

Q24 — Political foes. Are the alleged targets welfare recipients, individual public critics, opposition politicians, advocates or people selected by political affiliation? What supports each category without assuming recipients are opposition voters?

Q25 — Silence as objective. Do contemporaneous records show a purpose to discourage criticism or advocacy? Which actors can that purpose be attributed to?

Q26 — Chilling effect. Can reduced public criticism be distinguished from changes in media attention, policy, case numbers, exhaustion or other explanations?

Q27 — Political benefit. Is an electoral or coalition-building benefit documented as intended, and separately as realised? Does the reasoning avoid using presumed benefit as proof of motive?

Q28 — Schadenfreude. Is there direct evidence of pleasure specifically at others' suffering, rather than support for lawful recovery, fiscal restraint or punishment of proven fraud? Can prevalence be measured rather than illustrated with anecdotes?

Q29 — Personal attribution. Which findings belong to Morrison personally, portfolio ministers, Cabinet collectively or officials? Does any score have validated person-level interpretability?

Q30 — Historical exceptionality. Under a locked Australian comparison set and fixed criteria—scale, unlawfulness, automation, intimidation, targeting and correction delay—is Robodebt an outlier? Without that comparison, will the claim of no precedent be withheld?

Validity and falsification

Q31 — Provenance. Were scores constructed from contemporaneous sources, later findings or both? What source dates, prompts, model versions, judgements and revisions generated each observation?

Q32 — Actual blinding. Who has seen values, plots, summaries, keys, dates or related runs? What is concealed? Could trajectories identify entities? Will suspected recognition be recorded before reveal?

Q33 — Historical leakage. Could scorers or models know the outcome despite masked labels? If retrospective knowledge entered scoring, will claims be limited to retrospective discrimination rather than historical forecasting?

Q34 — Independent corroboration. Do scores and validation outcomes share documents or models? Can independent evidence be used, or must agreement be labelled shared-source consistency rather than external validation?

Q35 — Comparable scales. Are node definitions, anchors and organisational boundaries comparable across national, Cabinet, PM and CES/Centrelink records? Which comparisons fail if not?

Q36 — Resolution and dependence. How many independent intervals exist? Can sampling resolve the proposed ordering? How are nested entities, repeated dimensions and serial dependence prevented from becoming artificial replication?

Q37 — Specification stability. Do findings survive the finite, frozen set of justified baselines, lags, windows and missingness rules? Will every specified alternative be reported?

Q38 — Incremental CAMS value. Does CAMS add timing, localisation, discrimination or explanatory economy beyond a locked simpler comparator? What would show little added value?

Q39 — Symmetric judgement. Would the same rules identify Helm failure in another party's government? Can an independent blinded analyst classify the pattern without the preferred political narrative?

Q40 — Defeat conditions. What exact contrary chronology, absent asymmetry, effective correction, superior rival account, false-positive rate or source leakage would reject or materially narrow the hypothesis? Will rejection be reported prominently?

Implementation freeze

This question register does not specify every numerical test and must not be represented as a fully operational confirmatory protocol. Existing-data preregistration requires disclosure of prior exposure and a plan that prevents choices depending on observed results. See the Centre for Open Science guidance and secondary-data guidance. [cite:440][cite:446]

Before score access, freeze:

1. Exact dataset files, versions, hashes, custodians, date ranges, sampling intervals and entity lineage.
2. Person-by-person prior access, scoring involvement and knowledge; precise blinding and key-custody arrangements.
3. The current CAMS codebook, anchors, scale direction and existing formulae; one measurable signature per primary question.
4. Primary estimands, exact variables, comparison units and independently justified event dates and windows.
5. Resolution rules, minimum observations, same-period ambiguity and not-testable criteria.
6. One primary analysis method per question, assumptions and software. Sparse records do not justify complex causal modelling merely because many node scores exist.
7. Meaningful-effect thresholds, uncertainty treatment and decision criteria justified externally or by the existing codebook, not observed values.

8. The Q01–Q06 multiple-testing family. If valid p-values are used, proposed default: two-sided tests, Holm correction, family-wise alpha 0.05. An unavailable test provides no evidence and does not allow a substitute question. Freeze any alternative before access.
9. Missingness, exclusions, interpolation, institutional discontinuity, nesting and shared-source dependence rules.
10. A finite robustness set, negative controls, simpler comparators, complete reporting rules and amendment policy.
11. The analysis/reveal sequence and a stopping rule. No iterative rescoring to improve agreement with the preferred interpretation.
12. The separate evidence protocol for intent, targeting, audience response and historical comparisons if these are to be analysed.

If a necessary decision remains open, the affected analysis is exploratory or not testable. A symmetric similarity matrix cannot establish directional command or suppression. Derived network metrics are not independent replications of their input scores. Do not infer a minister's feelings from Capacity minus Stress, or malicious purpose from high Abstraction, without independent construct validation.

Classification and reporting

For each question report: **supported within this design; contradicted; inconclusive; not testable; or exploratory**. Temporal precedence is not proof of causation. Non-significance is not equivalence; meaningful absence requires adequate precision and an advance equivalence criterion.

Keep separate verdicts for executive responsibility, administrative distortion, deliberate intimidation, partisan targeting, pleasure in suffering and historical exceptionality. Support for the first two does not establish the last four. No CAMS result determines statutory corruption or criminal liability.

If the preferred account fails, state that clearly. A well-documented historical failure and an unsuccessful CAMS explanation can both be true.

Hash and external timestamp

Freeze exact bytes of this register, the completed implementation addendum, data manifest, codebook and analysis code. Calculate individual SHA-256 digests and preserve them in a manifest. Timestamp that manifest independently before access.

OSF Registries can archive files and metadata in a timestamped immutable registration. [cite:442] A completed OpenTimestamps proof can instead establish that committed material existed no later than an anchoring time; it does not establish truth or authorship. [cite:447][cite:454]

Recommended sequence: **freeze questions and implementation → freeze data and code → hash → obtain and retain external time evidence → run locked analysis under declared blinding → freeze results and suspected identities → reveal identity key → historical interpretation labelled separately**. If named events require earlier identity access, disclose that limitation.

The accompanying checksum is an integrity record, not an independently verified timestamp. No external registration or timestamp has been obtained in preparing this document. The preparation date is descriptive only. Amendments require a new version, new hash and time evidence, and an access-state declaration; preserve this original.